

“unretire” and go back to work. We used to work and then retire. This book suggests you work, then retire, then consider going back to work. Under this plan you devote your middle years to yourself and your family. During those years your mental and physical powers reach their height. You can explore, grow, and invest your time in what’s most important to you. You can enjoy your children while they’re still at home. Later, after you’ve lived the best years for yourself, you can go back to work if you want to. The choice will be up to you.

Pro athletes never plan forty-year careers. Martina Navratilova, Fernando Valenzuela, and Magic Johnson know their playing years are numbered. My work life lasted twelve years. To me, twelve years seems the minimum for a solid, proper career. But for football players, twelve years is the brilliant career of a superstar. Bob Griese, Herschel Walker, and Walter Payton may play twelve years. But most athletes burn out before they ever hit their Thirties Crisis. They may continue to dream of a chance to play in a Super Bowl, haggle over one more contract, or enjoy another headline. But their bodies scream at them to quit.

A tackle graduates from Ohio State and gets a signing bonus from the Raiders. For two years he draws a six-figure salary to play preseason games, beat up on special teams, and learn the playbook. In his third year he begins to start. Al Davis connects the name with the face, the fans and press talk about his quickness, and opposing players respect his talent. Our man plays three or four more years. During that period his salary doubles and then doubles again. He also makes big money on promotions and endorsements. But the travel, late nights, long workouts, mental strain, and injuries slow him by a fraction of a second. He begins to dread that inevitable Sunday when a younger player starts in his place. A season later he’s washed up, as useless as a water boy without a pail.

But our man hired an agent to help him make deals, invest, and prepare for retirement. When his playing career ends he can live the rest of his life on interest and